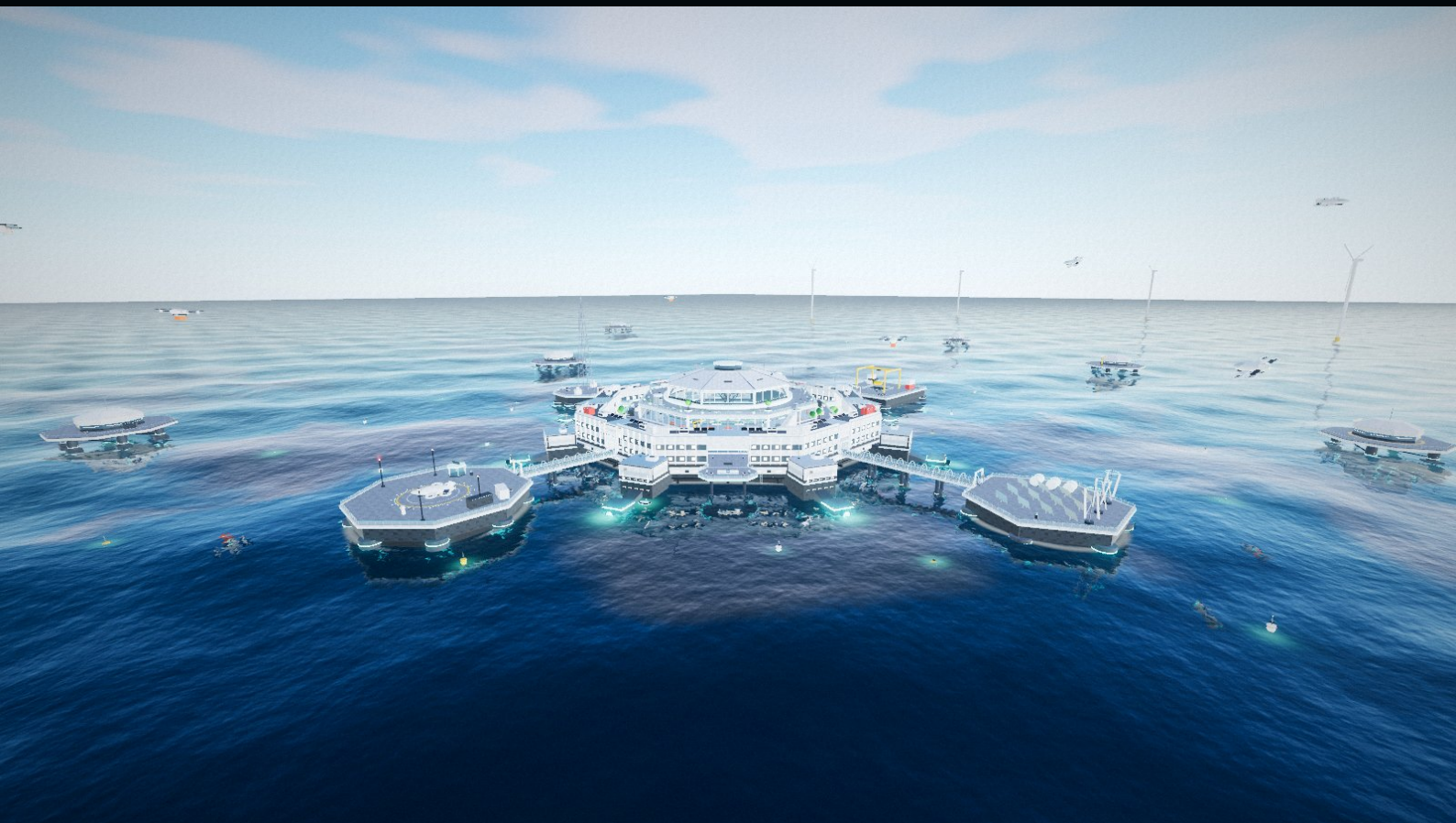


THE STORY OF



AEGIS

DEEP-OCEAN RESEARCH COLONY · PACIFIC SECTOR 7

Six chapters, one choice, two endings.

A first-person sci-fi exploration game · CFT Kinetic

BEFORE YOU BEGIN

The colony

AEGIS is a floating research colony three hundred and forty kilometres from the nearest coast. It is an octagonal city on the sea, with eight ring buildings around a garden atrium and its great tree, and satellite platforms joined by bridges: a landing pad, an energy platform, a marine dock with a moon pool and a submarine, and a comms mast. Forty-six people live and work there. They study what comes up from the Hadal Rift, a vent field almost eight kilometres down.

Thirty-six hours ago a storm cell passed over the colony. A power surge knocked out the command bus. The cryo lab sealed itself, the uplink went dark, and AEGIS stopped answering. The crew moved to the shelters on the Energy Platform. Commander Elena Reyes did not come with them.

You are the relief engineer flown in on VTOL-3 to find out why.

The people you will hear

LAYLA HADDAD · COMMS

Your voice on the radio from the Energy Platform shelter. Dry, calm and loyal to her crew.

SOFIA LINDQVIST · CHIEF ENGINEER

Runs the generators and the power grid. Knows every stair and hatch, official or not.

DR. KOFI OKAFOR · XENO BIOLOGY

Brought specimen AX-7 up from the Rift. He is fascinated by it and a little frightened.

CMDR. ELENA REYES

The colony commander, missing since the storm. She knows something the others do not.

SHORE COMMAND

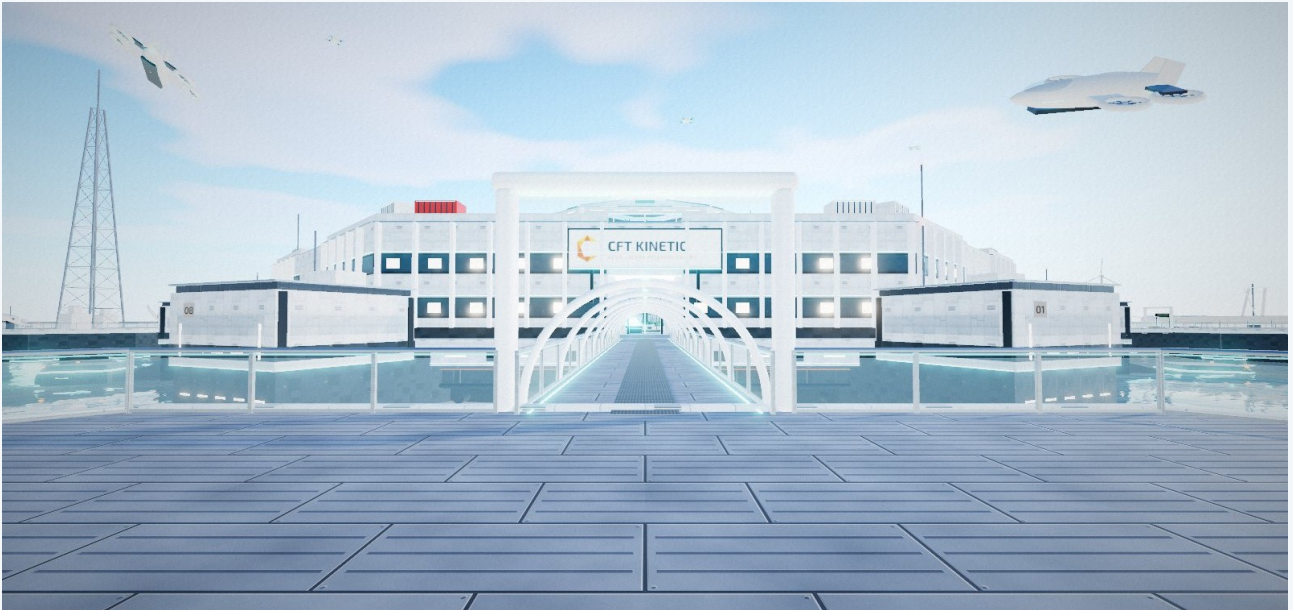
The company on the mainland. Polite, patient, and very interested in AX-7.

AEGIS · COLONY SYSTEM

The colony's own computer voice. It reports what it sees and never lies.

PROLOGUE

Silent for thirty-six hours



The landing pad. The lit bridge leads north into the colony.

PACIFIC SECTOR 7 · 340 KM FROM THE NEAREST COAST

AEGIS Deep-Ocean Research Colony. Forty-six crew. One storm.

Thirty-six hours ago, the colony went silent.

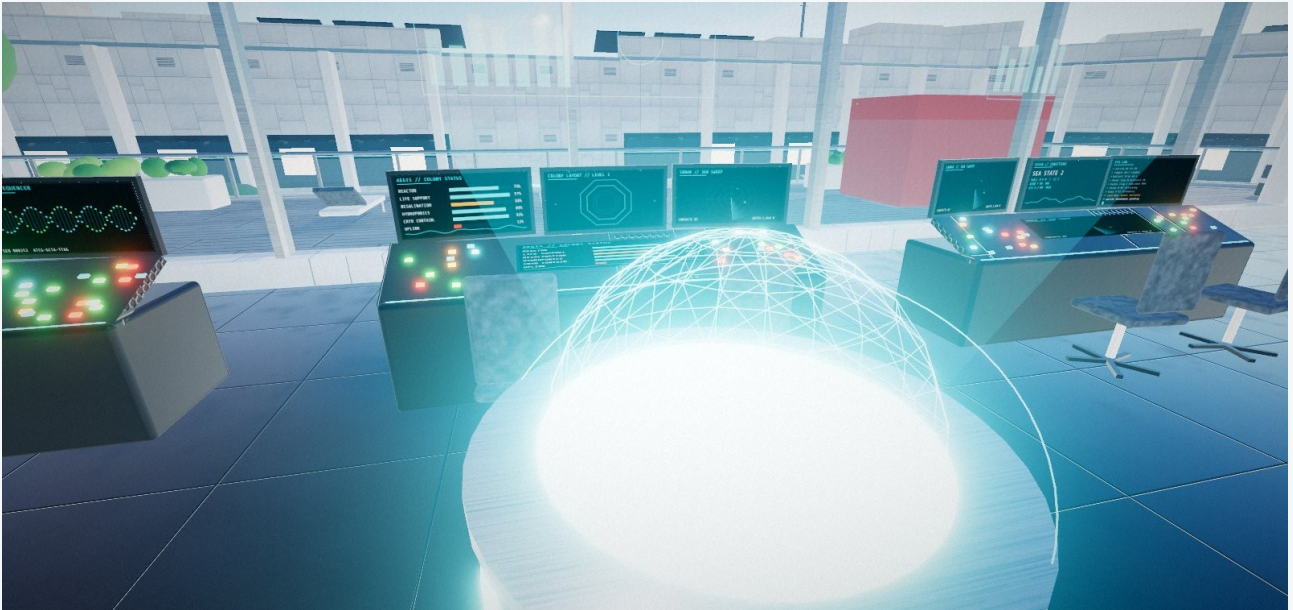
The crew made it to the shelters. Commander Elena Reyes did not.

You are the relief engineer. Find out what happened.

The VTOL settles on the pad and the rotors wind down. There is no one waiting. Across the bridge, the white ring of AEGIS sits on the calm sea with its lights on and nobody home. Then the radio clicks.

CHAPTER ONE

Silent Water



Mission Control, Level 2. The main console restarts the command bus.

Haddad sounds tired but relieved. The crew are safe in the battery hall on the Energy Platform, all except the Commander. Nobody has seen Reyes since the storm.

Inside, the colony greets you in its own flat voice. Main power is partial and the command bus is offline. The glass lift carries you up to Mission Control, where a long hold on the main console brings the systems back one by one.

The first message on the new line is not from the crew. It is from Shore Command. They want the AX-7 dataset, and they say “further instructions will follow”. Haddad does not like the sound of that.

ON THE RADIO

LAYLA HADDAD · COMMS

VTOL-3, this is Haddad on the Energy Platform. Good to hear an engine out there.

LAYLA HADDAD · COMMS

The crew are safe in the battery hall. All except the Commander. Nobody has seen Reyes since the storm.

LAYLA HADDAD · COMMS

Get inside and bring the command bus back. Mission Control is on Level 2.

ON THE RADIO

AEGIS · COLONY SYSTEM

Welcome, relief engineer. Main power partial. Command bus B offline. Cryo bay sealed.

LAYLA HADDAD · COMMS

That voice is the colony. The glass lift in the lobby will take you up to Mission Control.

ON THE RADIO

AEGIS · COLONY SYSTEM

Command bus re-sequenced. Uplink array on standby. Cryo bay still sealed: Level-3 clearance required.

SHORE COMMAND

AEGIS, this is Shore Command. Good work, engineer. Priority directive: secure the AX-7 dataset and transmit. Further instructions will follow.

LAYLA HADDAD · COMMS

Further instructions. They never say that. Reyes' Level-3 card should be in the Crew Lounge. She dropped it when the alarms went.

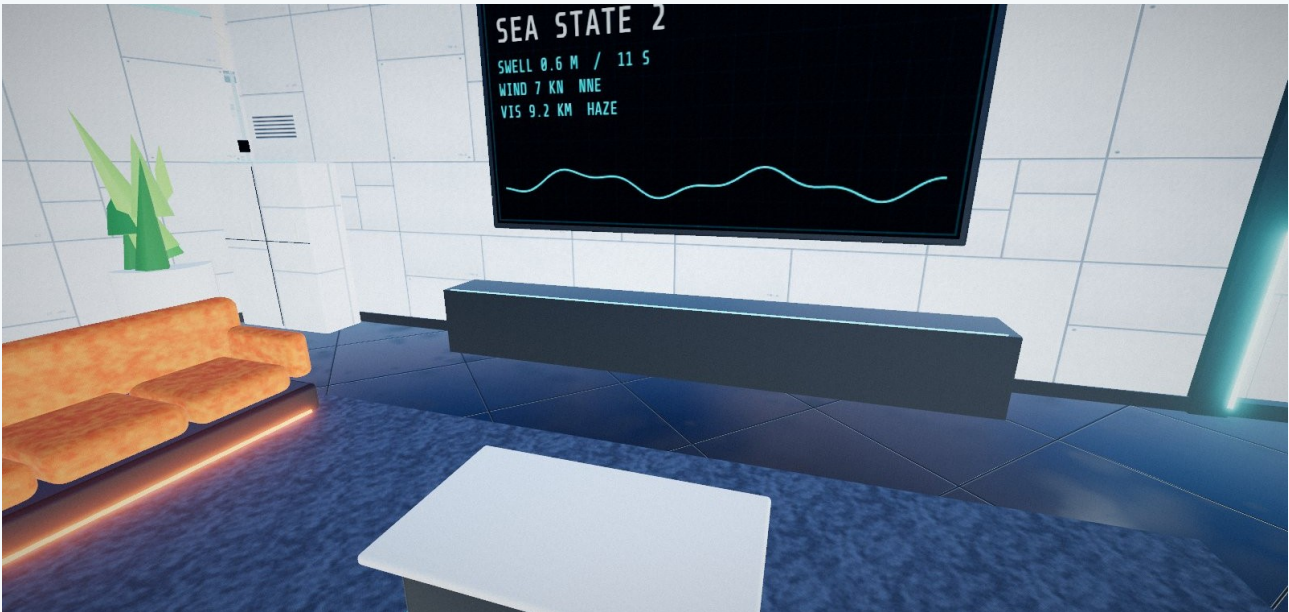
DATA LOG · COMMAND BUS FAULT

“Automatic diagnostic: command bus B offline since 14:12. Cryo bay sealed (fail-closed). Uplink array parked. Manual re-sequencing required from the main console. Commander authentication bypass enabled for relief crew.”

— Mission Control

CHAPTER TWO

Clearance



The Crew Lounge, where Reyes dropped her keycard when the alarms went.

The cryo lab only opens for Level-3 clearance, and the only Level-3 card on the colony belongs to the Commander. Her own log says she left it on the lounge table when the alarms went off.

The card is where she said it would be. With it, the red door off the ring corridor finally opens. There is another way in for anyone who reads the engineers' notes: a maintenance stair from Engineering drops to the service ring, and an unofficial hatch leads up into the cryo sublevel.

ON THE RADIO

LAYLA HADDAD · COMMS

That's her card. She'd laugh at you for finding it before she did.

DATA LOG · PERSONAL — CDR. REYES

"If anyone reads this: I left my Level-3 card on the lounge table when the alarms went. Stupid. The lab doors fail closed on a power fault, which is the right design and the wrong afternoon. Tell Lindqvist the service ring under Engineering still connects to the cryo sublevel."

— Cmdr. Elena Reyes

DATA LOG · SERVICE RING

"The service ring runs under the whole Level 1 corridor. Stairs up at Engineering (sector 6) and — unofficially — at the cryo sublevel (sector 4). The hatch there is meant to be for nitrogen line inspection. It is also how the night shift gets snacks to the cryo team."

— Maintenance

CHAPTER THREE

The Cold Room



The Cryogenic Laboratory. Specimen AX-7 floats in the primary pod.

It is cold inside the cryo lab and lit blue. Four pods stand in the room. In the largest one floats AX-7: bilateral and cephalopod-like, and faintly glowing at a wavelength no known animal uses.

Okafor asks you not to touch anything, just scan it and step back. The scanner hums and the dataset lands: 2.4 petabytes. Then the vital-signs screen changes. The neural trace, flat for days at minus one hundred and ninety-six degrees, starts to climb.

ON THE RADIO

DR. KOFI OKAFOR ·
XENO BIOLOGY

This is Okafor. Please don't open anything. Just scan it and step back. It should be asleep.

DR. KOFI OKAFOR ·
XENO BIOLOGY

Should be.

DATA LOG · SAMPLE AX-7 — PRELIMINARY

“Recovered at 7,900 m from the Hadal Rift vent field. Bilateral, cephalopod-like, but the tissue fluoresces at 488 nm without any known luciferin. Neural activity persists at -196 C. That should not be possible. Recommend full sequencing before we tell anyone on shore.”

— Dr. Kofi Okafor, Xenobiology

DATA LOG · CONTAINMENT PROTOCOL

“Primary pod AX-7: liquid nitrogen jacket, triple-redundant power. On main-power loss the bay seals and the pods fall back to the local cells for 72 hours. Access restricted to Level-3 clearance. Do not open the pods. Do not tap the glass. It taps back.”

— Cryo Bay Control

CHAPTER FOUR

Heartbeat



Breaker bank 3 in Engineering, the only way to keep the pod powered.

AX-7 is awake, and the pod draws more power than the reserve cells can give. The alarm sounds through every corridor and the lights flicker. Lindqvist comes on the line and tells you to reset breaker bank 3 in Engineering by hand, and to be quick about it.

You find the striped cabinet with its red lamp and hold the reset until the relays thump home. The alarm dies. Then Haddad calls, and she sounds different. A sensor buoy under the dock is pulsing in the same rhythm as the thing in the pod. And a suit beacon has come on down there. It is Suit D, the Commander's suit.

Shore Command cuts in to tell you that the Commander is not your priority.

ON THE RADIO

AEGIS · COLONY SYSTEM

Scan complete. 2.4 petabytes. Warning: neural activity in pod AX-7 is rising.

DR. KOFI OKAFOR ·
XENO BIOLOGY

It's awake. At minus one-ninety-six. That is not possible.

AEGIS · COLONY SYSTEM

Containment power draw exceeds reserve. Local cells failing.

SOFIA LINDQVIST · CHIEF
ENGINEER

Lindqvist here. The scan has tripped bank 3 again. Engineering, sector 6. Reset it by hand, and be quick about it.

ON THE RADIO

SOFIA LINDQVIST · CHIEF
ENGINEER

Containment is holding. Nice work.

LAYLA HADDAD · COMMS

Engineer, buoy S-14 is lighting up under the dock. Same rhythm as the thing in the pod.

LAYLA HADDAD · COMMS

And we've got a suit beacon down there. Suit D. That's Reyes' suit.

SHORE COMMAND

Engineer, the Commander's status is not your priority. Proceed to the uplink.

DATA LOG · ENGINEERING SHIFT LOG

“Storm surge tripped breaker bank 3, which took Mission Control and the cryo bay with it. Generators are fine — it is the command bus. Anyone who can reach the main console on Level 2 can re-sequence it. The maintenance stair beside the gennies drops to the service ring. Mind your head.”

— Chief Eng. Sofia Lindqvist

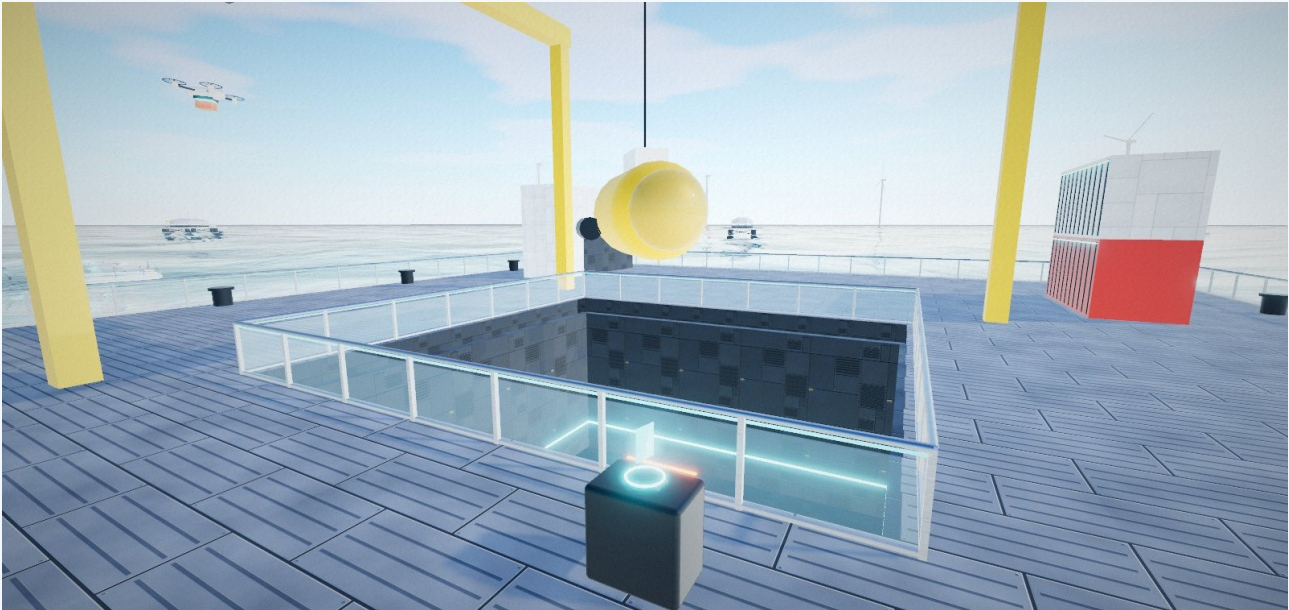
DATA LOG · HYDRO CORE

“Found it. The tree roots have grown through the reservoir inlet and into the nutrient tank. The water here glows the same 488 nm as AX-7 tissue. I have not told Okafor. I am not sure what I would tell him.”

— Dr. Ines Moreau

CHAPTER FIVE

Moon Pool



The Marine Dock. Reyes' recorder sits on a crate by the moon pool rail.

You cross the bridge to the Marine Dock. There is the yellow gantry crane and the submarine NEREID hanging over the square black water of the moon pool. On a crate by the railing, a suit recorder is still blinking.

It is Reyes. She took Suit D down the moon pool to meet what has been circling the colony. The recording explains what the logs only hinted at.

ON THE RADIO

LAYLA HADDAD · COMMS

...You heard all that. So did I. The uplink is on the roof, and what you send from it is up to you.

SHORE COMMAND

Engineer. Proceed to the uplink. That is an order.

DATA LOG · SUIT RECORDER — CMDR. REYES

"If you are hearing this, you came for the data. Listen first. AX-7 is not a specimen. It is a child. The thing under the dock is its mother, and she has called for it every thirty minutes since we lifted it out of the Rift. Shore Command knows. Their "further instructions" are a purge code: keep the data, freeze the body solid, forever. I am taking Suit D down the moon pool to meet her. Send the science if you must. Do not send the purge. — E.R."

— Cmdr. Elena Reyes

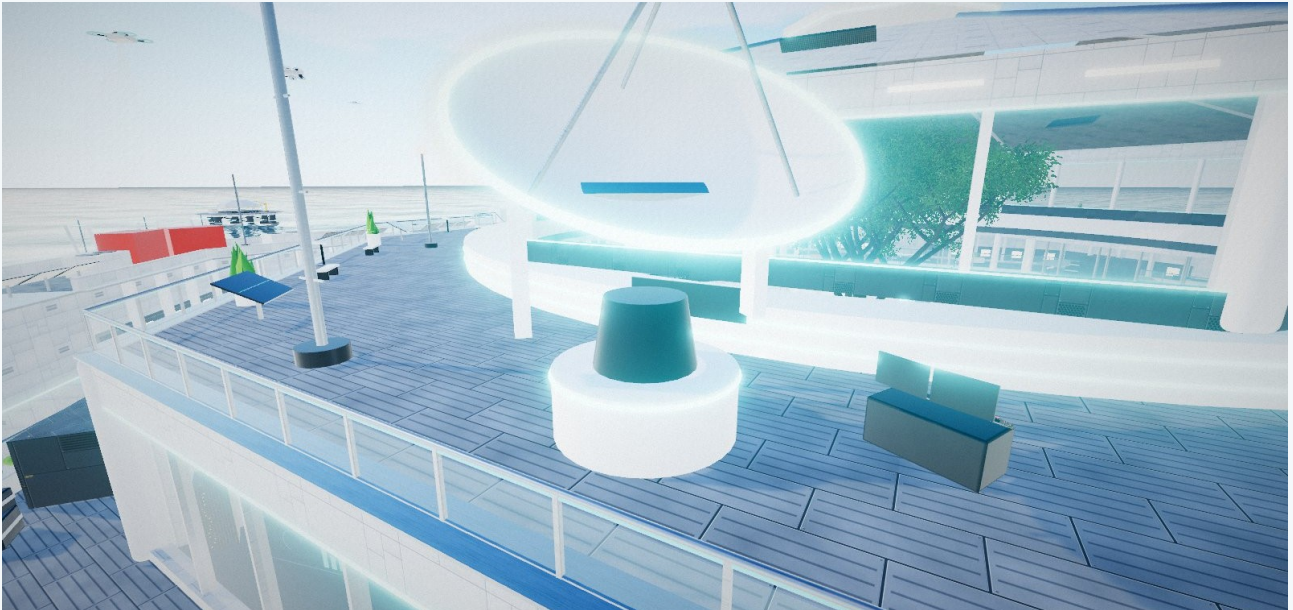
DATA LOG · MOON POOL LOG

"NEREID hoisted for seal service. Moon pool clear. Note: sensor buoy S-14 reports a large, slow return under the dock at 03:10, 03:40 and 04:10. Regular as a heartbeat. Diver check found nothing but the glow."

— Marine Ops

CHAPTER SIX

The Choice



The Observation Roof and the comms uplink dish.

Everyone is waiting on you now. You climb to the Observation Roof. The uplink dish swings to find the relay satellite, and the console asks for authorisation.

Shore Command has received the dataset. All it needs now is one more code, 7-7-OMEGA, which freezes AX-7 solid for good. Reyes asked you not to send it. Haddad says only that whatever you send, they will all live with it.

ON THE RADIO

SHORE COMMAND

Dataset received. Transmit authorisation code 7-7-OMEGA to complete the protocol.

COMMS UPLINK · AUTHORISATION REQUIRED

What do you send?

Shore Command wants code 7-7-OMEGA, which freezes AX-7 for good. Reyes asked you not to send it. Whatever you choose, the dataset goes to shore.

Send everything

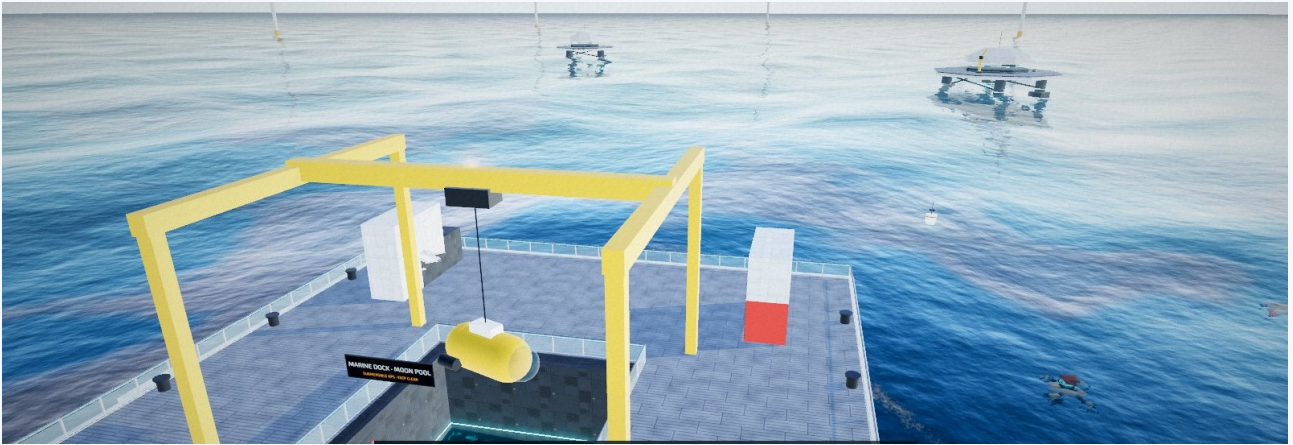
Transmit the dataset and the purge code. Follow orders.

Send the science only

Withhold the purge. Open the pod and let AX-7 go home.

ENDING · ORDERS FOLLOWED

The water went dark



Ending A. The Marine Dock after the purge.

ON THE RADIO

AEGIS · COLONY SYSTEM

Authorisation 7-7-OMEGA accepted. Cryo purge in progress.

AEGIS · COLONY SYSTEM

Purge complete. Pod AX-7: vital signs none.

SHORE COMMAND

Thank you, AEGIS. A recovery team will arrive in seventy-two hours. The crew will be reassigned.

LAYLA HADDAD · COMMS

...Buoy S-14 has gone dark. So has Suit D's beacon.

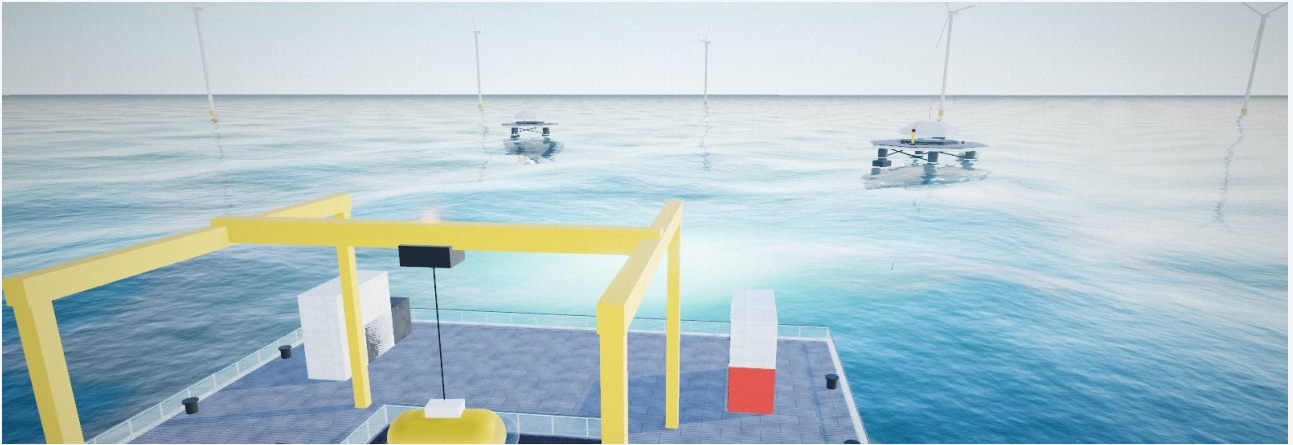
Seventy-two hours later, the recovery team arrived on schedule.

Nobody ever found Suit D.

The dataset is on its way to shore, and the protocol is complete. AEGIS is back online. The crew come home from the Energy Platform to a colony that works perfectly. The water under the dock stays dark, and nobody on AEGIS talks about why.

ENDING · THE SEA REMEMBERS

Two lights, heading home



Ending B. The Marine Dock as AX-7 goes home.

ON THE RADIO

AEGIS · COLONY SYSTEM

Purge authorisation withheld. Opening pod AX-7 to the moon pool.

DR. KOFI OKAFOR ·
XENOBIOLGY

It's moving. It's going down the pool. Oh — look at the water.

CMDR. ELENA REYES

This is Reyes. I'm on the moon pool ladder. She let me go. She didn't say anything, but I understood her.

SHORE COMMAND

AEGIS, respond. AEGIS—

LAYLA HADDAD · COMMS

Sorry, Shore Command. The uplink is acting up. Storm damage, probably.

Shore Command sent a very angry inspection team.

They never found anything in the water. The crew never told them where to look.

The science went to shore. The purge code never did. Commander Reyes climbed out of the moon pool at dawn. Two lights sank past the buoy line, one large and one small. Some nights the sea under AEGIS still glows, slow and regular as a heartbeat. The crew call it a thank-you.

APPENDIX

The data logs

Twenty logs are hidden around AEGIS. Together they tell the story the crew never told out loud.

Arrival Notice

AEGIS Flight Ops

Relief engineer inbound on VTOL-3. Colony has been silent for 36 hours after the Tuesday storm cell. Last telemetry: partial power fault, cryo containment on backup. Crew relocated to the Energy Platform shelters as a precaution. Restore systems, secure the specimen data, transmit.

Welcome to AEGIS

Reception Terminal

AEGIS Deep-Ocean Research Colony, Pacific Sector 7. Displacement 184,000 tonnes. Crew complement 46. Eight sectors on Level 1, the observation gallery and Mission Control on Level 2, the uplink array on the roof. Please do not feed the atrium tree after 22:00. It knows.

Atrium Garden

Dr. Ines Moreau, Botany

The ficus has grown 40 cm since the nutrient loop was rerouted through the hydro core below the floor. The roots now reach the reservoir. Whatever we are feeding it, it likes. The hydroponic rings are producing 30% of our greens; the rest still comes by drone.

Personal — Cdr. Reyes

Cmdr. Elena Reyes

If anyone reads this: I left my Level-3 card on the lounge table when the alarms went. Stupid. The lab doors fail closed on a power fault, which is the right design and the wrong afternoon. Tell Lindqvist the service ring under Engineering still connects to the cryo sublevel.

Sample AX-7 — Preliminary

Dr. Kofi Okafor, Xenobiology

Recovered at 7,900 m from the Hadal Rift vent field. Bilateral, cephalopod-like, but the tissue fluoresces at 488 nm without any known luciferin. Neural activity persists at -196 C. That should not be possible. Recommend full sequencing before we tell anyone on shore.

Containment Protocol

Cryo Bay Control

Primary pod AX-7: liquid nitrogen jacket, triple-redundant power. On main-power loss the bay seals and the pods fall back to the local cells for 72 hours. Access restricted to Level-3 clearance. Do not open the pods. Do not tap the glass. It taps back.

Suit Room Checklist

Marine Ops

Hardsuits A through D serviced. Moon pool depth 38 m under the dock. Submersible NEREID rated to 8,000 m, currently on the gantry for seal replacement. Anyone taking the sub past the buoy line files a plan with Mission Control first. That means you, Tanaka.

Engineering Shift Log

Chief Eng. Sofia Lindqvist

Storm surge tripped breaker bank 3, which took Mission Control and the cryo bay with it. Generators are fine — it is the command bus. Anyone who can reach the main console on Level 2 can re-sequence it. The maintenance stair beside the gennies drops to the service ring. Mind your head.

Letter Home (unsent)

Pilot Kenji Tanaka

You would love it here. The sea is so calm some mornings it looks like glass, and the drones leave little green lights under the water all night. I fly the supply runs, twice a week. Some nights I think the sea glows back. Probably just the buoys.

Galley Notice

Galley

Tuesday is algae pasta. Wednesday is algae pasta with a different sauce. Thursday the drone brings real tomatoes. Whoever keeps putting kelp in the coffee machine: the coffee machine has filed a complaint with Mission Control.

Observation Gallery

Facilities

Level 2 gallery runs the full ring except Mission Control. Telescopes are calibrated for the horizon line; the offshore wind farm is 900 m to the north. On clear evenings the energy platform turbines are visible from here, and so is the aquaculture ring to the north-west.

Watch Rota

Security

Two on the gallery, one on the roof, rotating every four hours. Report any contact on the sonar board that the buoys do not see first. Last week the buoys saw something the sonar did not. We logged it as a whale.

Command Bus Fault

Mission Control

Automatic diagnostic: command bus B offline since 14:12. Cryo bay sealed (fail-closed). Uplink array parked. Manual re-sequencing required from the main console. Commander authentication bypass enabled for relief crew.

Uplink Array

Comms Officer Layla Haddad

The dish tracks the relay satellite over the southern horizon. When it fires you can see the beam in the haze — do not stand in it. Shore command expects the AX-7 dataset the moment we are back online. They have been very insistent. More insistent than usual.

Service Ring

Maintenance

The service ring runs under the whole Level 1 corridor. Stairs up at Engineering (sector 6) and — unofficially — at the cryo sublevel (sector 4). The hatch there is meant to be for nitrogen line inspection. It is also how the night shift gets snacks to the cryo team.

Hydro Core

Dr. Ines Moreau

Found it. The tree roots have grown through the reservoir inlet and into the nutrient tank. The water here glows the same 488 nm as AX-7 tissue. I have not told Okafor. I am not sure what I would tell him.

Energy Platform

Chief Eng. Lindqvist

Twelve solar arrays, three vertical-axis turbines, 40 MWh of storage. The crew is sheltering in the battery hall until the command bus is restored. Morale is fine. Someone brought cards. Someone else brought a kazoo. Please hurry.

Moon Pool Log

Marine Ops

NEREID hoisted for seal service. Moon pool clear. Note: sensor buoy S-14 reports a large, slow return under the dock at 03:10, 03:40 and 04:10. Regular as a heartbeat. Diver check found nothing but the glow.

Suit Recorder — Cmdr. Reyes

Cmdr. Elena Reyes

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Relay Mast

Comms Officer Haddad

The mast backs up the roof array for short-range links: drones, buoys, the VTOLs. It stays up on its own batteries, which is why you could still land. You are welcome.